

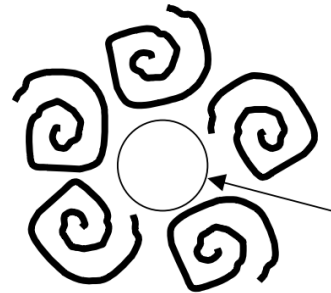
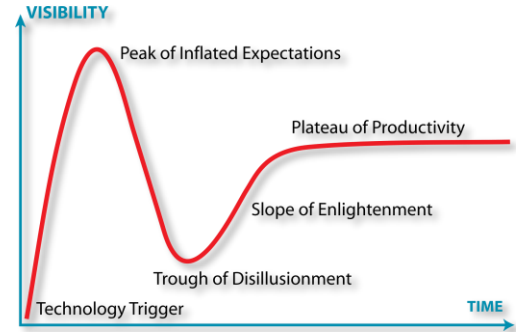
Ordinary uses of extraordinary technologies

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Extra/ordinary technological innovation

- Technology studies show us that technological innovation and cultural change occur in long, non-linear processes (e.g. Shove 2003 or Wajcman 2016).
- Argument: studying the banal uses of technologies (high tech or otherwise) allow us to critically comprehend real techno-cultural changes that is happening.

**Linear models of
industrial
innovation
(Gartner 2003)**



**Non-linear and cyclical
realities of techno-
cultural change
(Shove 2003)**

The hype of TikTok power

- TikTok and its high-tech hype is surrounded by accounts of (a) its ability to influence culture, (b) addict people, or (c) read and control their minds by algorithmic means.
- How high tech is TikTok really?

“TikTok confirms that its own employees can decide what goes viral” (TheVerge 2023).

INFLUENCE

What is TikTok? Everything you need to know about the app changing the cultural landscape

Millions are playing the TikTok fame game — and the winners are influencing what we watch, listen to and read. No wonder Facebook is rattled

Digital Crack Cocaine: The Science Behind TikTok's Success

CONTROL

ADDICTION

How TikTok Reads Your Mind

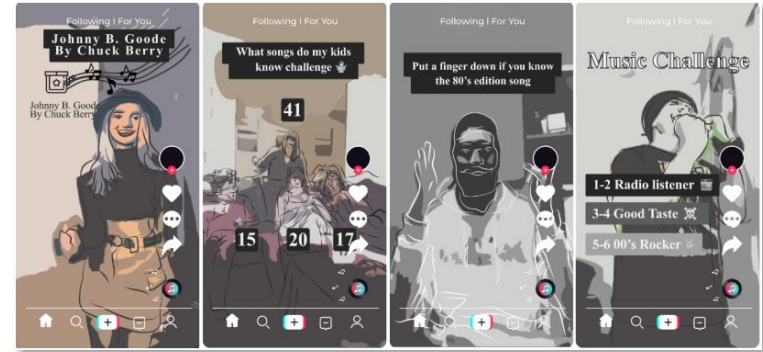
It's the most successful video app in the world. Our columnist has obtained an internal company document that offers a new level of detail about how the algorithm works.

The hype of TikTok culture

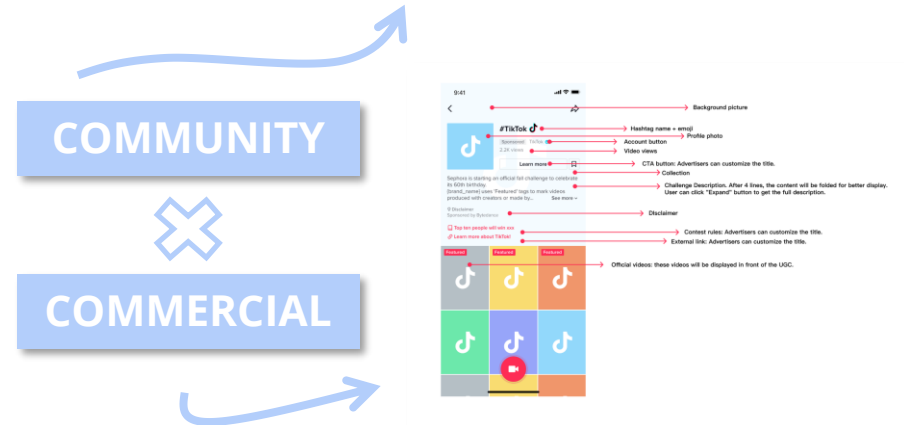
- TikTok as site of bottom-up, playful, and youth cultural activity (see Boffone 2021, Kaye et al. 2022, Su 2023, Vizcaíno-Verdú and Abidin 2022).

➤ However, who participates?

"The typical TikTok user posts seldom, if ever. About half of all U.S. adults on the site have never posted a video ... the typical user has not added any information to the 'bio' field on their account." (Pew Research 2024)



Source: Vizcaíno-Verdú and Abidin (2022)



Exploring the hidden worlds of TikTok

- Consumption as private, invisible practice (despite traces in likes, comments, etc).
- Yet fundamental activity to both the experience and participation in TikTok culture, yet also the app's commercial relevance.
- Extending our interest beyond high-tech innovation to the banal, everyday realities of such.



**High-tech
innovation
happening inside
corporate walls**

**Banal high-tech
use happening in
private spheres
of everyday life**



Digital ethnography of TikTok consumption

Methods



Digital fieldwork on
TikTok app (0.5 year)



Interviews with
TikTok users

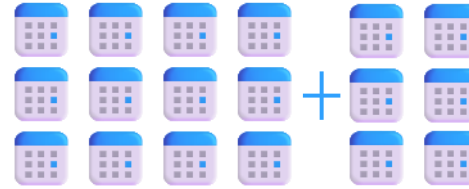


Media mapping
techniques



Participant observation
of scrolling behaviour

Fieldwork



1.5 years of
fieldwork in
2020/21

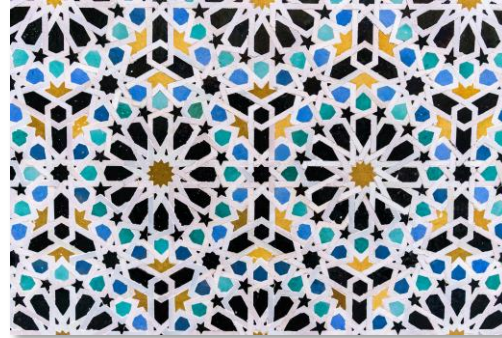
Working with group of
30 UK-based young
adults for 1 year



Ephemerality as communicative affordance

- Going on TikTok was about disconnection and managing degrees of connection (echoing Miller 2011).
- It was about feeling meaningfully connected to the world yet without pressure or social obligations.
- "Part of the reason why I like it and keep using it is just ... the content on it is a lot more inspiring and optimistic ... it's like 'oh look at this cool meal I made' or 'here's how to do this and that'"

Scrolling is like sitting in a café, looking outside, observing fleeting events as they pass by.



Personalised content feeds are mosaic structures, assembling fragments of lived experience.

Ready-to-hand comfort devices

- Participants used TikTok to pass time. For instance, while waiting or feeling bored (i.e. involuntarily slowdown of daily life).
- Boredom as “experience without qualities” (Goodstein 2005), incapacity in the “framing action of habit” (Anderson 2004).
- “I was just sitting on the bench outside the hairdressers, and I was just on it [TikTok]. I won’t actively be like ‘oh my god, I really wanna go on it’. I’ll probably just do it when I’m bored and when I’m passing the time.”



Like the worry beads, fidgeting practices like that of scrolling help deal with various everyday experiences.

Like reading a magazine, the experience is flexible, can be picked up and putdown again quite easily (Hermes 1995)



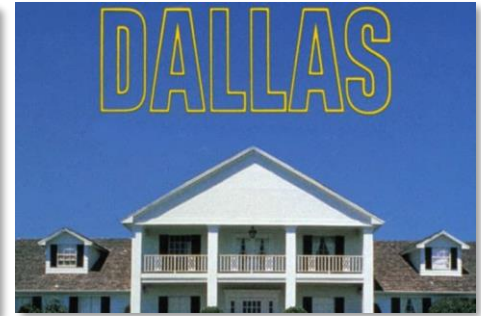
Listening to ordinary strangers like “you”

- Appeal of TikTok amongst participants was a perceived authenticity and relatability associated with TikTok (see also Barta and Andalibi 2021).
- Parallels to prior genres like soap operas, their emotional realism (Ang 1985) and relatability of stories (Herzog 1940).
- “Being on TikTok is like seeing what your friends were up to if you friends were all kind of cool and you didn’t have any obligation towards them.”



The reliability and perceived authenticity of TikTok remedies the “ordinary strangers” persona of amateur film (Zimmermann 1995)

Similar kind of emotionally realistic and imaginative escapism like that of soap operas (Ang 1985)



Sharing to stay in touch with significant others

- All participants frequently engaged in the act of sharing videos with others. Primarily they did so by sending them the video either on TikTok or on another messaging app.
- Inherently social dimension to it: “TikTok is personal but also interactive with how you can just ... without directly messaging someone, you can just let them know that you are thinking of them”

Similar to greeting cards, sharing videos allows to create moments of affinity, connections that make relationships (Mason 2018)



Likewise, we see echoes of commercialisation here in the expression of sentiments and emotions (West 2018)

Across the board TikTok...



...aggregates the ordinariness of prior media devices and genres in high-tech form.

- Taking a look at the outside world
- Fidgeting and browsing to fill time
- Listening to stories of ordinary strangers
- Staying in touch with significant others

... extraordinarily problematises prior cultural techniques in various ways.

- Ubiquitous and sticky surveillance
- Illusively programmed media offering
- Excessive cultural commercialisation
- Accelerated commodification of attention

Changing how we study technology

- Avoiding hype by outlining the continuities of cultural practices and media technological forms (echoing Bolter and Grusin 1999).
- Putting to the fore an analysis of the on-the-ground realities of media technologies and their material cultures (Miller et al. 2021).
- Engaging in more patient and descriptive modes of thinking that outline a fuller picture of our media cultures (Gumbrecht in Ekman 2006; Gumbrecht and Pfeiffer 1994).

Outline the continuity of cultural practices

Foregrounding the materialities of media

Enhancing our descriptive accuracy of media practices

Changing the way of how we envision technology

- Moving from idealistic ideas of meaning, happiness, good life towards anthropological meanings of “good enough life” (Miller 2023).
- Thinking beyond eudaimonic fulfilment and happiness, but everyday pleasures that emerge from within commodified spaces (Lefebvre 2014).
- As such, envisioning new models of online life that take movement and interoperability as starting points for our reflection (Markham 2020).

**Engaging anthropological
forms of meaningfulness**

**Envisioning new forms and
spaces of everyday pleasure**

**Embracing the
interoperability**

Summary

- As a case, TikTok does not just exemplify the ever-advancing commercialisation of the internet through technological innovation. On the ground, TikTok also exemplifies a lived reality where high-tech artefacts fulfil fundamentally ordinary purposes.
- As much as we need critical engagement with the extraordinary nature of high-tech phenomena like TikTok, we also need scholarship that showcases the continuities of ordinary social practice that surround such.
- In the parallel view of the extra/ordinary, will we be able to paint a much fuller picture of technological infrastructures like the internet, which will in consequences allow us to better envision its future.

Thanks!

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